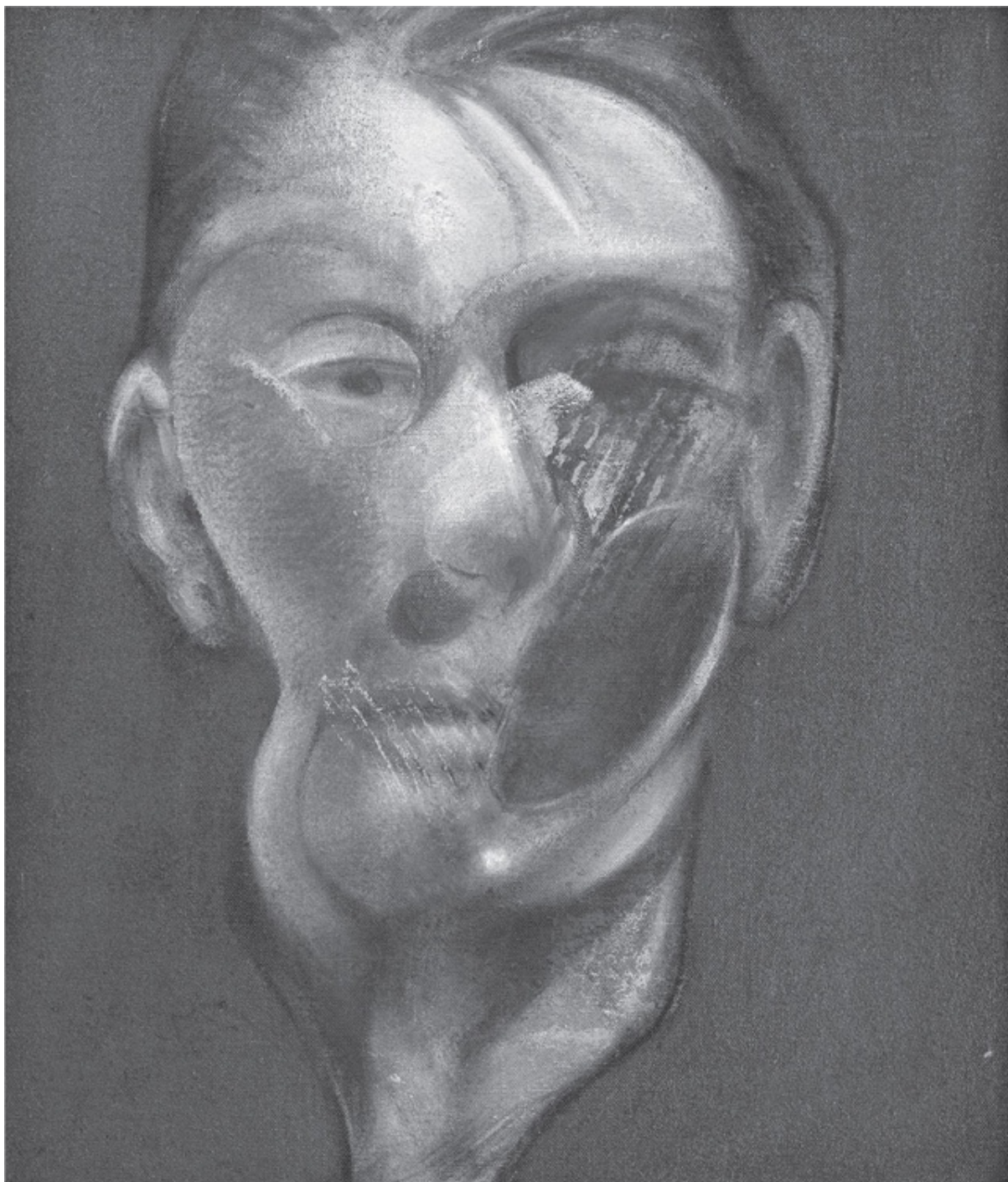


School of London

In 1976, at the height of Minimalism and Conceptualism, the London-based American painter R.B. Kitaj (1932–2007) organized an exhibition at the Hayward Gallery titled 'The Human Clay'. Consisting exclusively of then-unfashionable figurative drawing and painting, the exhibition proved highly controversial. In the catalogue, Kitaj used the term 'School of London' to describe the exhibiting artists, who also included Michael Andrews (1928–95), Frank Auerbach (b.1931), Francis Bacon (1909–92), Euan Uglow (1932–2000), Lucian Freud (1922–2011), Hockney, Howard Hodgkin (b.1932) and Leon Kossoff (b.1926). Rather than a coherent style or approach, the 'School' was held together by friendship and a strong belief in figurative painting, despite contemporary fashion.

Each artist expressed his ideas in intensely personal work – Bacon, for instance, used distortion to express emotions such as desolation, cruelty and fear, while Freud's later work built up impressions of flesh with thick, granular paint. Despite the initial controversy, the School of London inspired many younger artists.



Bacon, *Self-Portrait*, 1976